CodexVault Manual

Deutsch | English

CodexVault is a local macOS backup and restore tool. Its interface supports English and German; English is the default. This manual describes the functionality that is implemented now; it does not describe planned features as if they already existed.

Before you begin

- CodexVault requires macOS 26.
- Select sources and destinations explicitly. The app does not begin a normal backup automatically.
- Keep complete backups only in a trusted local destination: they can contain sensitive local Codex data.
- A normal backup and a complete backup have different exclusion rules. Read the relevant section before choosing one.

Navigation

The sidebar contains five sections. Its header also has official **Discord** and **GitHub** mark buttons. They open the public community or CodexVault repository only after you click them; no app data, selected folders, or backup contents are passed to either website.

The sidebar contains five sections:

Section	Purpose
Overview	Starting point and current status cards. The Activity area appears only after a backup has been created in the current app session.
Backup	Normal backups, complete ZIP backups, and local Codex storage review.

Section	Purpose
Restore	Validation and selective restoration of a normal backup package.
Archive	Previously created, verified normal backups whose package folders still exist.
Settings	Appearance, privacy status, and build-channel information.

The **Start setup** button on Overview opens Backup.

First-start help

When CodexVault has no own folder selection, full-backup configuration, or created backup content yet, Overview shows a friendly first-start screen.

- **Set up backup** opens Backup. No backup starts automatically.
- **Open manual** opens this public English manual when the app uses English, or the public German manual when the app uses German.
- The ChatGPT, Google Gemini, and Claude buttons show a confirmation first. After you choose **Copy and open**, CodexVault copies only a prepared general question with the public manual link and confirmed public facts about the app, then opens the selected service. The question explicitly tells the service not to invent features such as vaults, snippets, tags, or a code editor.
- Paste the copied question yourself with Cmd+V and decide yourself whether to send it. CodexVault does not open a service automatically and never transfers backup content, paths, credentials, or other personal app data to a service.

Once you add your own selection or configuration, or create a backup, the regular Overview is shown instead. Its **AI help** card keeps the same manual and service buttons permanently available.

Normal backup

Use a normal backup when you want a portable package for exactly the folders you choose.

1. Open **Backup**.
2. In **Sources**, click **Add project** for a project folder, **Add folder** for any additional folder, or **Import ChatGPT export** for a local `conversations.json` file or ChatGPT export ZIP. You can add more than one source.

3. Wait for the preview. It shows the number of included files and estimated size for each source. Use the remove button beside a source to remove it from this pending selection.
4. In **Backup destination**, click **Choose destination** and select a writable folder. Use **Change** to choose another destination.
5. Review the summary at the bottom. **Create verified backup** becomes available only when at least one source and a destination are selected.
6. Click **Create verified backup** and wait for the success message.

Password protection

Turn on **Encrypt this backup with a password** before creating a normal backup. The password is not stored. To restore an encrypted package, choose it in Restore, enter the same password, select the verified contents, and restore them normally. A lost password cannot be recovered.

What is created

CodexVault creates a new folder with the `.codexvault` extension inside the chosen destination. It includes:

- `manifest.json` with the package schema, logical source names, relative file paths, exclusion counts, and SHA-256 checksums.
- The selected source folders directly at the package root. There is no technical `payload` folder.

The app verifies the package after creation. Existing files in the destination are not replaced.

Normal-backup exclusions

The preview and normal backup exclude typical sensitive or generated material, including `.env` variants, file names containing token, secret, or credential, common certificate/key formats, Git metadata, build folders, dependency folders, and common cache folders. A visible warning reports the count of sensitive files excluded from the preview.

This is name-based protection, not a guarantee that every possible secret is detected. Review your selected source before sharing a package.

Complete ZIP backup

Use **CodexVault full backup** when you want a recurring local ZIP copy of automatically detected Codex app data and your configured project folders.

1. Open **Backup** and find **CodexVault full backup**.
2. Click **Add project folders** and select one or more project folders that should be included in future complete backups. You can repeat this action to add further folders; it does not replace the existing list.
3. Review the visible project-folder list. Use **Remove** beside a folder only when it should no longer be included; the other configured folders remain.
4. Click **Change destination** and choose the trusted local folder where the ZIP files should be stored.
5. Confirm the displayed project-folder list and destination.
6. Click **Create complete ZIP backup**. The progress bar and message show the current phase.

Use **Search projects** to choose a local folder for a one-time scan. CodexVault shows only suggestions with recognizable project markers; nothing is added until you select it. Automatic full backups can be enabled daily or weekly while CodexVault is open. They do not run in the background and wait until the separate Codex desktop app is closed. Keep CodexVault open for the backup.

The project-folder choices and destination are stored locally for the current macOS user. Codex app data is detected automatically. A visible Codex workspace is detected only while a complete backup runs; it is not shown as a configured project folder on a fresh start. No external backup script must be selected.

Files, verification, and retention

For every available source, CodexVault creates a dated ZIP and updates a separate `latest` ZIP copy. It verifies each new ZIP with the system ZIP validator before reporting success.

After a successful run, CodexVault may offer to remove dated backups beyond the newest three per source. The dialog lists a destructive option and **Keep all**. Nothing is deleted until you choose the destructive option.

Complete-backup exclusions

Complete backups are designed for continuity and therefore are more inclusive than normal backups. For Codex data, temporary data and IPC files are excluded. For configured project folders, common build and dependency folders are excluded. The resulting ZIPs can still contain sensitive work and Codex data; do not treat them as safe to share publicly.

Codex storage overview and local-record cleanup

The **Codex storage overview** helps you understand local Codex disk use before you remove anything.

1. In Backup, click **Check storage**.
2. Review the total local records and size, then the storage categories.
3. Review **Local records grouped by project**. A record can be associated with a current project, earlier local work, or have no current project assignment.
4. Use **Collapse** to hide the existing result. In the current app session, **Check storage** reopens the same preview; restart the app to create a new analysis.

If **Unassigned local records** are shown, select only records you no longer need. Click **Remove selected local records**, then explicitly choose **Remove permanently** in the confirmation dialog. This removes only selected local session-record files that are not currently assigned. It cannot be undone.

The storage overview itself is read-only. It does not remove records unless you select them and confirm the destructive action.

Restore a normal backup

Restore works with a verified `.codexvault` package.

1. Open **Restore**.
2. Click **Choose Backup** and select a backup package.
3. Wait for validation. If it fails, the package is not available for restore.
4. Under **Verified contents**, select the logical sources to restore. They are selected initially after successful validation.
5. Select a **Restore destination**.
6. Click **Restore selected** and wait for verification to finish.

CodexVault creates a new restore folder below the selected destination and verifies restored files against the package checksums. It never overwrites existing destination files. Packages with schema versions 1, 2, and 3 are accepted when they pass validation.

Archive

Archive keeps a local list of normal backup packages that CodexVault created and verified. It shows their verification state, file count, and size across later app starts as long as the package folder still exists. Missing package folders are removed from the list. Archive is not a disk browser: it does not scan a destination folder or import packages that CodexVault has not previously created and registered.

Settings

Language

Use **Settings > Language > App language** to choose **English** or **Deutsch**. English is the default. The choice changes the visible app interface, the first-start AI-help text, and the manual opened by **Open manual**. It does not change selected sources, backup contents, existing packages, or security decisions.

Appearance

Preview theme changes only the current app appearance. It does not change selected sources, backup contents, security decisions, or an existing package.

Theme	Appearance
Liquid Glass	Native glass treatment on the left navigation panel.
Full Glass	One continuous milky glass surface across the complete window, with a slow diagonal cyan/blue/purple/pink glow and a denser field of softly glowing, irregular light points across sidebar and content. The animation pauses when macOS Reduce Motion is enabled and while a backup, restore, or storage analysis is running.
Graphite & Lime	Dark graphite interface with lime accents.
Midnight	Dark blue/indigo interface.

The selected theme is currently a session setting; it is not documented as a persisted preference.

Privacy

The Privacy section displays that automatic network activity is disabled and that the app does not keep a private content catalog. Public website links and AI services open only after an explicit click and receive no app data. File permissions are always requested through explicit folder choices. The locally saved complete-backup setup stores only the configured folder and destination references needed to run that feature, not a backup-content catalog.

Build channel

The section shows the running build channel. Dev, Beta, and Final use separate bundle identifiers and separate sandbox containers. Data is not migrated between them.

Errors and safe next steps

Message or situation	What to do
No source or destination selected	Add at least one source and choose a writable destination.
Package could not be verified	Do not restore it; choose another package or create a new verified backup.
Complete ZIP backup failed	Check that the destination is writable and sources are available, then retry.
Older complete backups are offered for removal	Choose **Keep all** unless you have reviewed the retention decision.
Unassigned records are listed	Do not delete by size alone; select only records you recognise as no longer needed.

Feature documentation rule

When a user-facing feature changes, update the feature lists in both READMEs and the matching sections of both manuals in the same change.